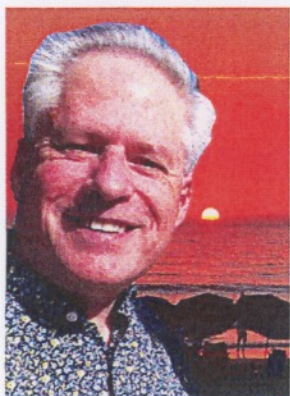


## MEET YOUR FACILITATORS



**The Rev. Dale Suggs** earned a BA in Religion Studies and Computer Science from Texas Christian University ('83) and a MDiv from Brite Divinity School ('87). He holds Graduate Certificates in Ecumenical Studies from the University of Geneva ('88) and Spiritual Direction from the University of San Diego ('07). He also is a Certified Facilitator of the Compassion Practice through Claremont School of Theology ('16).

Dale is an ordained minister in the Christian Church (Disciples of Christ). He has served as Senior Minister in 3 congregation in Indiana and Southern California, as Intentional Interim Minister in 4 congregations in Southern California and Arizona, and as a Hospice Chaplain in San Diego.

In 2018, Dale and his wife, Shelly (CST '17), co-founded an alternative-model congregation based in San Diego called **BELOVED** Way. Grounded in grace, inclusion and compassion, BW is organized around spiritual practice and engages in compassion-based outreach especially in mental health.

In 2020, Dale and Shelly also co-founded the nonprofit, **BELOVED** Compassion Network. BCN facilitates spiritual practices that provide the "how to" of "making compassion a way of life" for individuals, teams and organizations. BCN also offers online support groups for trauma care.

Dale is a teacher, speaker, and retreat leader specializing in compassion, spiritual practice, and "breaking the silence" about mental health in the church. He provides Spiritual Direction for students at Disciple Seminary Foundation and Phillips Theological Seminary. Dale and Shelly will celebrate 42 years of marriage in August. They have 4 beautiful daughters and 4 wondrous granddaughters.



**The Rev. Rachel Cooley Shawler** is a pastor, sister, sometimes-yogi, spouse, youth mentor, chaplain, and soon-to-be mother. She claims New Mexico as home but grew up all over the US and lived a few years in Germany growing up with a dad in the Air Force. Becoming fascinated by culture & peoples, she majored in Sociology and English Literature during college in San Antonio, before serving as an Americorps member in a high-need, low-income school there.

The challenges of that service plus a major loss in her family led Rachel to deeper church engagement, and she experienced a call to ministry in community there. Vanderbilt Divinity School was next, where the Disciples

House through the Christian Church (Disciples of Christ) instilled a commitment to openness with colleagues and theology explored in community (MDiv '21). Rachel has served 3 churches including one program-sized, one pastor-sized and one family-sized which welcomed queer folks in the otherwise unwelcoming panhandle of Florida.

Rachel's move to San Diego for her husband's medical residency invited hospital chaplaincy training, yoga teacher training, and Compassion Practice experience. In our stressful lives & sometimes callus culture, she refocuses on getting grounded in our bodies and holding space for emotional vulnerability. She continues to be interested in integrating these practices in community life, small groups, and pastoral care. Rachel is now preparing to move to Baltimore, MD and saying goodbye to a pastor-sized United Church of Christ congregation where she's served as Associate Minister of Youth and Community-Building.

As I'm in my 6<sup>th</sup> year of ministry, and getting ready to close out my service at Kensington UCC in San Diego, I'm in a particularly rich moment for reflecting on where I've grown, yes, but also what I've gotten lost in along the way.

At first, and in the transitional time just after seminary, I was constructing my faith & integrating it into my life & service and it felt good. But the pressures of employment & getting paid & certainly some of my own demons & life difficulties that arose had me kind of lost for a while.

How did I wind up in a place lately where too high a percentage of my work at church is administrative & logistical? And it feels like more time behind the computer is soul-sucking. Not to mention that lots of people don't even answer my emails. How did I wind up feeling like it's wrong for members to ask me about me, especially during this pregnancy, and receive their care graciously & gratefully?

Not taking time to prepare my pieces for worship as much, let alone pray for the people or meditate in the community. Does putting people on the prayer list & sending a note to others about them count as praying? And does that count as my time in my own faith?

For a while about 2 years post-seminary, I kept asking "what is ministry" getting caught in my head or intellectualizing but masking this deeper, desperate feeling. An overwhelming feeling I didn't really want to touch, so I'd just keep busy, keep in my head.

And when my coach pointed it out to me, mostly I'd blame myself, like I should be able to just shake such things off, know that hustling & numbing wasn't part of co-creating with God, I'm a minister for goodness sake.

But she'd remind me, and I had to remind myself over & over that I'd been taught to hustle & intellectualize all my life. And that the church space I was in was forming me by their expectations too, and my unconscious reactions to them, and my grasping for more certainty or comfort in getting things done, planning youth events, reminding folks about meetings. I know some administration is necessary & I'm willing to serve, though, so I'd keep going. A

strange self-sacrificing thing emerged. Which of course I'd also been taught all my life as a woman & youngest sibling & by others around me modeling poor boundaries with work & service to others.

Once I analyzed all this & used reminding myself of the environment as a coping mechanism so I wouldn't blame myself, though, I wound up often stuck in cynicism, with no sense of agency to change it, so I just kept going.

Confirmation... I'd gone to the meetings, collaborated, emailed the families & mentors the plans, and eventually offered an edited but mostly similar format for our Confirmation Service to our folks. Come to find out, one of the youth had felt left behind weeks ago, and it came back to me: I knew the small group in which he shut down & I knew I hadn't really been there for him in that moment, validating his questions in the group & inviting him in. I was so tired that day, I was frustrated with him even, not paying attention more, how I thought he should, to the things that had been prepared for him with difficulty. Now I'm not saying we can't get frustrated with our people. But now he didn't want to present at the service & furthermore he didn't feel he'd gotten much out of the program. His mom had made him come, and I feel I let them down, and she seemed a bit icy with me now too, even as she validated that it's near impossible to even hear what's wrong from him when he shuts down like he had. I felt like I'd lost the thread, the focus on nurturing faith, and so had he. Now he might not have really picked up on it anyway, but it was a moment of reorientation for me.

families don't come to church now for more programming. Their lives are over full. Of course they don't want to respond to my emails, their days are so packed with replying & coordinating anyway.

What do they come for? And what did I get in this for in the first place? I'd gotten so caught in "what is ministry" & hustling that I'd forgotten my seminary reflection that ministry is not so much about *what* you do but *how* you do it.

And I'd forgotten my particular gifts, which are about holding sacred space for vulnerability. Although I'm here to tell you based on my performance review

- relationally, with depth, over time

So easy to critique, we're taught to. What are we building, what are we doing right. it's normal to self doubt and even good to self examine. But it's also good to build ourselves up and remember the intrinsic gifts we have. Sometimes our job descriptions don't feel like they match: we have to find outlets and know that they're gonna come out anyway, through God's spirit thanks be

Early ministry can feel extra vulnerable. Older people are projecting their shit onto us or we want them to be trustworthy leaders but find they're not.

We may want to accept any role we can, we think we can't get to what we want just yet, we need exposure

We need someone to pay us. The scars of capitalism & current wounds/needs. That our value is what we're paid. Learning it's true that people value what they pay for in some ways. But that's not the only thing they value, by God's spirit thanks be.

Knowing you have value, who you are and who's your are and the gifts you intrinsically have & aint nobody gonna get rid of em that's impossible because god made them ... sacred moments, your call

What are my specific gifts / not fitting this mold I think I see laid out for me or is valued by our grind culture brainiac professionalism

We have to be reminded cause they other stuff is so loud



which happened just last week, quite behind schedule but yet offered by the congregation, that my gifts have been shining through anyways. They lifted up how I see people, how my communication responds to their needs, and how I name their unmet/unspoken needs too & attempt to integrate them into what the church does, even if I don't always succeed.

The question is "what is ministry" and how can I fit & succeed, but "who am I" with God, what gifts does God delight in with me.

the good news is that there ain't nothing I can worry about or do that will hide them away completely. I can see that with the benefit of hindsight. But what if I could soak in a sense of my call & God's love with me more often in the present moment? What if I could live it out more fully day to day? and remind myself genuinely & more often that what I offer is enough?

Now I'm not gonna say I'm ...  
but the Compassion Practice has offered me  
a way

how do we get back to God?

not that God is 'just some touching feely  
feel good

triggers from seminary

Communal healing from whiteness, yes

how do you care for your inner world?  
take time to reflect

come back to the feelings in the moment,  
Sometimes a momentary pause is all needed  
there are other deeper things we <sup>don't</sup> realize are  
at play

In & out of your role they expect of you  
Not some kind of must do  
the dam, but there's the flow — how God responds  
to you

what is the church, Christians  
the need is so great

white supremacy culture  
force spirituality in itself  
invisible to us

transcendence  
not God

anti-racism compassion practice

Communal

Ubuntu  
I-thou

youth ministry  
spirituality project  
Mark Yaconelli

Selfish  
↓